

Cold Storage Operations Review: A Customer Perspective Case Study

Type of Analysis: Observational Process & Workforce Analysis

Business Problem

A cold storage retail facility (frozen goods and fish) was experiencing long checkout queues and inconsistent service quality, visible enough that regular customers were commenting on it. The facility operates multiple product sections, each staffed by a dedicated attendant, but funnels all customer payments through only two staff members — one handling online transfers, one handling cash.

The core business question: **why were queues forming, and what operational factors were driving inconsistent customer experience?**

This mattered beyond a single bad visit — repeated friction at checkout and inconsistent staffing directly risks customer retention in a competitive retail environment.

The Data

This was an observational case study, not a formal data-driven engagement. Data was gathered through:

- **Direct, in-person observation** of store operations during a live visit — queue formation, staff movement, and a real-time staffing incident (a cashier being pulled from his post and replaced by an untrained substitute)
- **Informal customer conversations** while waiting in queue, surfacing recurring patterns (meeting different staff on different visits, perceptions of management style)
- **Structural observation** of facility layout and staffing model (sections vs. centralized payment)

Limitations of this data are addressed in Section 4.

Result of My Analysis

Key Observations

#	Observation	Impact
1	Only two staff handle all payments store-wide; no trained backup exists	Significant slowdown when either is pulled from post
2	A disciplinary conversation happened mid-shift, during peak hours	Directly disrupted service during the busiest period
3	Customer's report meeting a different worker nearly every visit	Erodes customer familiarity and trust
4	Staff speak different languages; management speaks two	Limits real-time coaching and floor oversight
5	Frequent new/unfamiliar staff faces reported by regulars	Suggests underlying turnover, not isolated staffing gaps

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Root Cause Analysis

Symptom	Root Cause
Long queues during the incident	No trained backup for payment roles – a structured staffing gap, not a one-off event
Disruption during peak hours	Poor sequencing of disciplinary action – reactive rather than planned
Inconsistent service	Likely downstream effect of turnover and lack of standardized staffing/rotation
Supervision gaps	Manager's language limitation restricts real-time oversight of staff interactions
Recurring new faces	Underlying turnover issue – cause unconfirmed, but likely tied to pay, scheduling, or management style

Recommendations (Prioritized)

1. **Build payment-role redundancy** — cross-train 2–3 additional staff so payment stations are never left uncovered. (Low cost, immediate impact)
2. **Investigate turnover** — informal exit conversations or surveys to identify the driver. (Addresses root cause of multiple issues)
3. **Move disciplinary conversations off the floor** — handle after closing hours. (Easy, no-cost fix)
4. **Address the supervision/language gap** — basic language support or a bilingual assistant supervisor. (Longer-term, lower urgency)
5. **Standardize service delivery** — consistent staffing rotations where feasible.

Limitations

Limitations:

- This analysis is based on a single site visit and customer-vantage-point observation — not internal data (staffing records, turnover rates, sales/queue-time metrics)
- Root causes around turnover and language impact are inferred from pattern and conversation, not confirmed via management interview or HR data
- Sample size for customer sentiment (informal conversations) is small and not statistically representative

Open to entry-level Business Analyst / Junior Analyst / Operations Analyst roles. Feel free to connect on [LinkedIn](#) or reach out via [email](#).